education centre. Thenkalai Vaishnavism centred on Srirangam. Vadakalai sect focused on Vedic literature, which is written in Sanskrit. The Thenkalai sect stressed the importance of *Divya Prabandhams,* written by the 12 Azhwars in Tamil.

2. Bhakti Movement in North India

While dealing with the religious movements of the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries in northern India, one has to keep in mind the two very different attitudes which Hindu religious leaders had towards Islam. One group accepted what was best in Islam; the other adopted a few elements in order to prevent conversion to Islam. Both reacted to Islam, but one was sympathetic while the other was hostile. Kabir and Guru Nanak, and other founders of new sects are included in the first group, while the movement in Bengal, associated with Chaitanya deva, or Chaitanya Mahaprabu, belongs to the latter tendency.

(a) Exponents of Bhakti Movement

It was Ramananda who spread the Bhakti ideology in northern India where it became a mass movement. Vallabhacharya, a Telugu philosopher, built a temple for Lord Krishna on the Govardhan Hills near Mathura. Surdas, a blind poet and musician, was associated with this temple as well as that of Agra. His famous collection of poetry is called *Sursagar.* Meera Bai, wife of the crown prince of Mewar, was an ardent devotee of Lord Krishna. She was a disciple of Ravidas. Meera Bai gained popularity through her *bhajans.* Chaitanyadeva popularised Krishna worship through ecstatic songs and dancing that had a profound effect on Vaishnavism in Bengal. In the 16th century, in Tulsidas's Hindi retelling of the story of Rama in the *Ramcharitmanas,* the sentiment of friendship and loyalty is stressed. Many of those poems continue to be recited and sung often at all-night celebrations.



Ramananda


Vallabhacharya


Surdas


Meera Bai


Chaitanya



Tulsidas


Tukaram


Panduranga Temple, Pandaripuram

Tukaram, a 17th century saint poet of Maharashtra, is known for his spiritual songs (*abangas* or *kirtanas*), devoted to Vitthoba, an avatar of Krishna. There is a Vitthoba/Panduranga temple at Pantharpur or Pandaripuram in Sholapur district, Maharashtra. What is Chaitanyadeva to Bengal is Tukaram to Maharashtra.